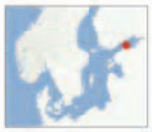
THE RUSSO-SWEDISH WAR

SECOND BATTLE OF SVENSKSUND



Location Svensksund, Gulf of Finland

Date July 9–10, 1790
Forces Swedish: 6 sailing ships, 18 galleys, 172 other vessels; Russians: 30 sailing ships, 23 galleys, 88 other vessels
Losses Swedish: 1 sailing ship, 4 smaller ships; Russians: 10 sailing ships, 16 galleys, 17 other vessels

The Second battle of Svensksund was an immediate sequel to the battle of Vyborg Bay. The Russians under Prince Charles of Nassau-Siegen pursued the Swedish galley flotilla, commanded by King Gustav, to Svensksund. There the king's force was joined by a squadron under Colonel Carl Cronstedt and anchored in a strong defensive position. They spread out in a crescent formation blocking the entrance to Svensksund Harbor, with their gunboats on the wings and their sailing ships and galleys in the center.

Nassau-Siegen prepared to attack on July 9 and went ahead with his plan on the day, despite the fact that a fresh wind and choppy sea created conditions that were far from ideal for galley warfare. He arranged his ships in four squadrons, one on each flank and two in the center. The battle was hard fought but soon turned in Sweden's favor. On both flanks the Russians were met with determined fire from the Swedish gunboats, supported by shore batteries, and were gradually pushed back. By the afternoon the Swedes, first on the left and then also on the right, had achieved a position from which to turn inward and rake the Russian galleys and sailing ships in the center from both sides. The galleys were soon in desperate trouble, taking damage and being swamped by waves. As rowers left their benches to man the pumps, some vessels drifted aground or sank. Around 7:00 p.m. Nassau-Siegen ordered a withdrawal. Many of his sailing ships could not get away and were boarded—either taken as prizes or burned. Night ended the day's combat, but fighting resumed the following morning, this time with the Swedes on the attack and the Russians striving to escape. Several more Russian ships were lost in the confused flight. Although exact figures for losses sustained in the battle are hard to establish, the Swedes had inflicted a major defeat on a superior enemy. Unable to crush Sweden, Russia accepted the need to make peace the following month.



Swedish naval reward medal
Inscribed to King Gustav III, this medal depicts Victory standing on a two-masted galley with a wreath in each hand.

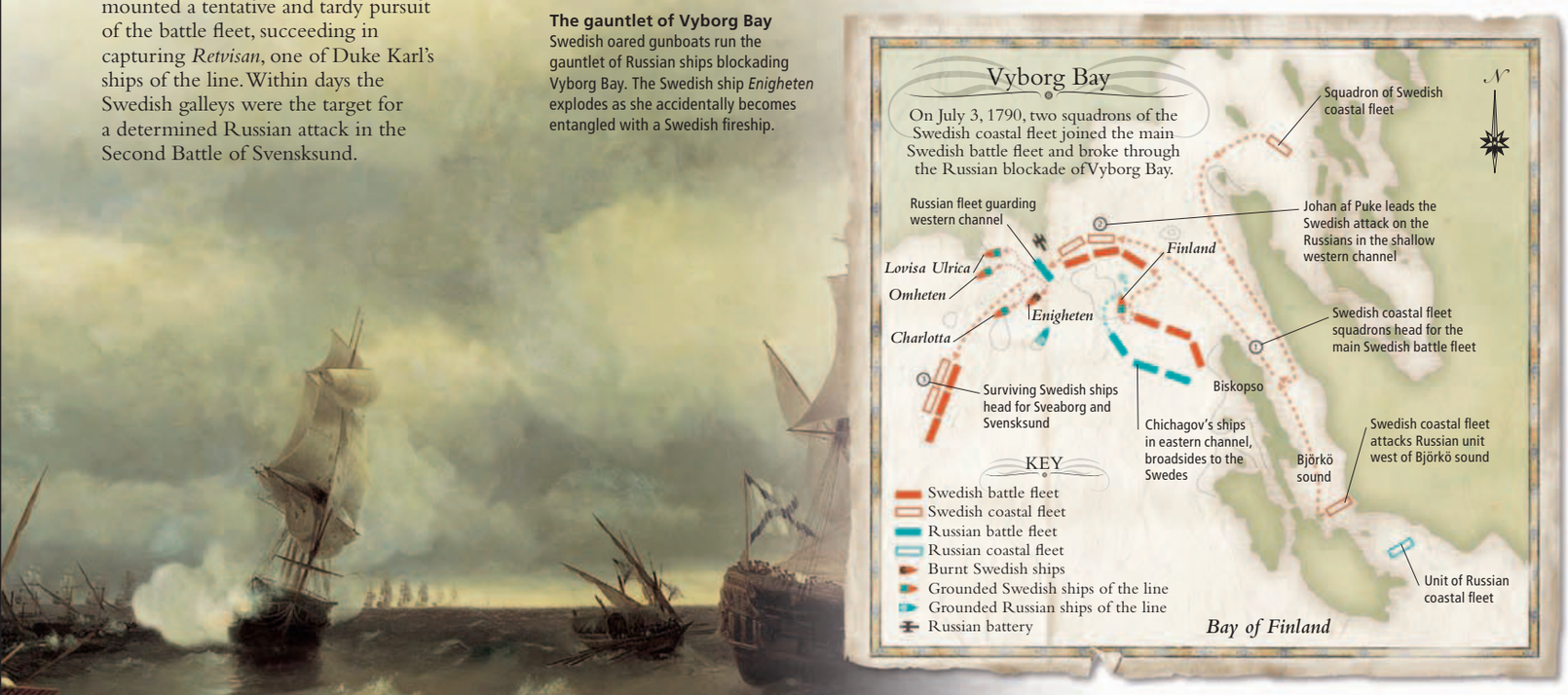


Russian ships of the line
Prince Charles of Nassau-Siegen arrives with the Russian fleet to face the Swedish force anchored at Svensksund Harbor.

ships ran aground, King Gustav's British naval adviser Sidney Smith needing to be rescued from one of them.

Despite these losses, both the Swedish battle fleet and galley flotilla broke out into the Baltic; the former sailed for Sveaborg in Finland for repairs; the latter took shelter at Svensksund, where it anchored in a strong defensive position. Russian admiral Chichagov mounted a tentative and tardy pursuit of the battle fleet, succeeding in capturing *Retvisan*, one of Duke Karl's ships of the line. Within days the Swedish galleys were the target for a determined Russian attack in the Second Battle of Svensksund.

> CAPTAIN DENISON ... HAD HIS HEAD SHOT OFF BY A CANNONBALL ... CAPTAIN AIKEN HAD HIS THIGH-BONE SHATTERED SO AS TO RENDER AMPUTATION NECESSARY ...
>
> **WILLIAM TOOKE**, HISTORIAN, WRITING IN 1798 OF BRITISH OFFICERS IN RUSSIAN SERVICE AT VYBORG BAY



The gauntlet of Vyborg Bay
Swedish oared gunboats run the gauntlet of Russian ships blockading Vyborg Bay. The Swedish ship *Enigheten* explodes as she accidentally becomes entangled with a Swedish fireship.